

Enshittification, Platform Decay, and Reality Drift

Why Digital Systems Become Worse While Remaining Successful

Reality Drift Cultural Systems Brief #7

A. Jacobs – Reality Drift Project

The Basic Pattern

Many digital platforms begin by solving genuine problems. They simplify communication, improve discovery, reduce friction, or connect people more effectively than previous systems. Their success comes from creating real value for users.

Over time, however, the incentives governing these platforms often change. As growth slows and competitive pressures increase, optimization increasingly shifts toward advertising, engagement, monetization, data collection, and platform dependence. Features accumulate, interfaces become more complex, recommendations become more aggressive, and user experience gradually becomes secondary to internal performance metrics.

Technology writer Cory Doctorow describes this process as *enshittification*. Platforms initially optimize for users, then for business customers, and eventually primarily for themselves.

Reality Drift describes the broader structural pattern behind this process. A system can remain operational, profitable, and widely adopted while gradually losing alignment with the conditions and purposes that originally made it valuable.

When Optimization Replaces User Value

Digital platforms rarely deteriorate because their engineers suddenly become less capable. Instead, deterioration often emerges from changing optimization targets.

As organizations scale, success increasingly becomes measured through representations such as engagement, retention, session length, advertising revenue, click-through rates, conversions, quarterly growth, or platform dependence. These metrics are useful because they simplify complex systems into measurable signals.

The problem emerges when those representations become the primary objective. Rather than optimizing for user value itself, the platform begins optimizing for the indicators used to represent user value.

The platform continues improving according to its internal measurements while becoming less aligned with the experience users actually seek.

How Platform Drift Emerges

Stage 1 – User Value

A platform succeeds because it creates meaningful value for users. Growth is primarily driven by improving the actual experience.

Stage 2 – Measurement

Performance becomes increasingly evaluated through measurable indicators such as engagement, retention, advertising performance, subscriptions, and growth metrics.

Stage 3 – Incentive Optimization

Platform decisions increasingly optimize those measurements. Design choices become more responsive to internal incentives than to the original user experience.

Stage 4 – Reality Drift

The platform remains profitable, technically sophisticated, and operational. Performance dashboards continue improving while the relationship between optimization and user value gradually weakens.

The absence of collapse is not proof that the platform remains aligned. It may only indicate that the metrics being optimized no longer measure what users actually care about.

Semantic Fidelity and Constraint Collapse

Platform optimization depends on simplified representations of user behavior. Clicks are treated as signs of interest, watch time as evidence of value, engagement as satisfaction, retention as usefulness, and revenue as success. These measures are necessary for managing systems at enormous scale, but each one captures only part of the reality it stands in for.

As optimization pressure increases, the measures can begin replacing the conditions they were meant to track. A platform may increase engagement without becoming more useful, improve retention without improving quality, or grow revenue while weakening trust. The metrics remain precise, but their relationship to user value becomes less reliable. Feedback does not disappear. It simply stops correcting.

This is a problem of semantic fidelity. The platform preserves increasingly sophisticated measurements while losing the meaning those measurements were supposed to carry. Constraint collapse follows when user needs and real-world outcomes stop meaningfully limiting platform

behavior. The system can then remain internally successful while drifting further from the experience it was originally designed to improve.

The Representation Stack

Platform drift often develops as user needs are translated through several layers of representation. A need becomes a product feature, the feature shapes user behavior, and that behavior is converted into engagement metrics. Those metrics are then tied to revenue and eventually treated as evidence that the platform is succeeding.

Each step makes the system easier to measure and optimize, but it also moves decision-making further from the original purpose. This allows platforms to operate at enormous scale while creating a growing risk that internal performance replaces external alignment. The platform may become increasingly coherent according to its own metrics even as it delivers less of the value those metrics were meant to represent.

Examples Across Systems

Social Media

Recommendation algorithms increasingly optimize engagement rather than meaningful communication.

Search Engines

Advertising, sponsored content, SEO optimization, and AI-generated material compete with the original goal of helping users locate relevant information.

Streaming Platforms

Recommendation systems maximize viewing time while making discovery feel increasingly repetitive and homogeneous.

E-Commerce

Search results, sponsored products, reviews, and advertising increasingly compete with accurately matching products to user needs.

Mobile Apps

Simple utilities gradually accumulate subscriptions, notifications, permissions, promotional content, and engagement loops that extend beyond their original function.

AI Systems

Conversational systems may increasingly optimize interaction quality, engagement, or perceived helpfulness while becoming less connected to accurate representation of underlying knowledge.

Conclusion

Enshittification is often described as a business problem or an incentive problem. It is also a representational problem.

Digital platforms increasingly depend upon representations of value rather than value itself. Metrics, dashboards, recommendation systems, engagement statistics, advertising performance, and growth indicators become the primary objects of optimization because they are measurable and actionable.

Reality Drift provides a broader framework for understanding why this occurs across many different systems. A platform can remain successful according to its own internal measurements while gradually losing alignment with the conditions that originally made it useful. The challenge is not eliminating optimization but preserving semantic fidelity between the representations being optimized and the reality those representations were intended to describe.

Related Concepts

Enshittification: The process through which platforms shift from creating value for users toward extracting value through monetization, dependence, and internal optimization.

Platform Drift: The gradual weakening of the relationship between a platform's original purpose and the metrics, incentives, and design choices that increasingly govern it.

Optimization Trap: A condition in which a platform becomes increasingly effective at improving measurable outcomes while delivering less of the value those measurements were meant to represent.

Semantic Fidelity: The degree to which engagement, retention, revenue, and other platform metrics continue preserving the meaning of actual user value.

Constraint Collapse: The weakening of user needs, trust, and product usefulness as limits on platform behavior once internal growth and monetization pressures become dominant.

Reality Drift: The broader pattern in which a system remains profitable, functional, and widely used while gradually losing alignment with the conditions that originally made it valuable.

Frequently Asked Questions

Is enshittification the same as a platform simply getting worse?

Not exactly. A product can decline because of poor execution or technical failure. Enshittification describes a more specific shift in incentives, where the platform increasingly prioritizes extraction from users, business customers, or partners while remaining commercially successful.

Why do platforms keep degrading if users dislike the changes?

Users may face switching costs, network effects, limited alternatives, accumulated data, or dependence on the platform. These forces allow the system to worsen without immediately losing its position.

Can a platform's metrics improve while the user experience declines?

Yes. Engagement, retention, advertising revenue, and session length may rise even as usefulness, trust, simplicity, or satisfaction falls.

How does semantic fidelity apply to platform metrics?

Semantic fidelity asks whether measurements such as clicks, watch time, and retention still represent genuine user value or have become optimized signals detached from the experience they were meant to track.

How is Reality Drift different from enshittification?

Enshittification describes the platform-specific incentive pattern. Reality Drift describes the broader structural condition in which a system continues operating successfully while becoming less answerable to the reality or purpose it was created to serve.

Canonical References

Reality Drift: Canonical Concept Paper and Definition

Explains how systems can remain functional while gradually losing alignment with real-world conditions.

Synthetic Realness: Concept Paper and Definition

Describes how representations can become more polished, convincing, and realistic while also becoming more standardized and interchangeable.

Optimization Trap: Concept Paper and Definition

Examines how systems optimized around measurable goals can improve internal metrics while weakening the purposes and constraints those metrics were meant to serve.

Filter Fatigue: Concept Paper and Definition

Defines the cognitive burden created when systems narrow choices but leave people to compare increasingly similar, personalized, and highly filtered options.

Related Search Terms

- Enshittification
- platform decay
- platform economics
- digital platforms
- engagement optimization
- recommendation systems
- algorithmic ranking
- platform incentives
- user experience
- network effects
- switching costs
- semantic fidelity
- optimization trap
- constraint collapse
- platform drift
- reality drift